

Weekly Theta Shortlist — 2026-08-31

Window: Run date 2026-08-31 (Mon). 50-day earnings-free window closes **2026-10-20**. Names reporting on or before that date are excluded.

Regime this week

VIX printed a fresh 2026 low into last week’s close, with the tape leaning into a dovish Powell after Jackson Hole — market-implied odds of a September cut are north of 90% (Fed funds still 4.25–4.50%). Powell flagged tariff pass-through as 'clearly visible' and downside labor risks rising, so the tail is hawkish-surprise, not dovish-disappointment. WTI is up ~5.6% MoM to ~\$85 on renewed Iran/Strait of Hormuz friction (US strike on rocket launchers reported); an energy-IV re-rate is the live idiosyncratic tail. No mega-cap blow-ups in the base universe — no exclusion changes on crisis grounds this week.

Tier A — October reporters (cleanest window)

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earn.	DTE	Justification
1	MSFT	Software / Mega-cap	~\$3.6T	~22–28% (Verify at IBKR)	~18–24% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-10-28 (unconfirmed)	58	Cleanest large-cap Oct reporter after the Oct 20 window close. Beta ~0.9, not a true high-beta name. IV usually sits at the low end of the 20–40% band except into print. Watch: date is a Wall Street Horizon forecast — reconfirm before opening; if MSFT confirms earlier than Oct 28, drop it.

Tier B — November reporters (verify against that window)

#	Ticker	Sector	Mkt Cap	Est. IV band	Est. HV band	Weeklies	Next Earn.	DTE	Justification
1	CSCO	IT Hardware / Networking	~\$260B	~22–28% (Verify at IBKR)	~18–24% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-11 (projected)	72	Fiscal Q1 FY27 typically mid-Nov. IV runs in the low-to-mid 20s away from print. Steady FCF; low earnings gap risk historically. Date projected — reconfirm within 2 weeks.
2	HD	Home Improvement Retail	~\$400B	~22–28% (Verify at IBKR)	~18–25% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-17 (CONFIRMED)	78	IR confirms Q3 FY26 release 11/17. Housing-tape sensitive but current rate-cut path supportive. Preferred core position — deepest liquidity in the retail cluster.
3	LOW	Home Improvement Retail	~\$135B	~23–30% (Verify at IBKR)	~20–26% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-18 (tentative)	79	IR calendar shows 11/18 tentative. Behaves like HD with more torque. Pair the HD/LOW clustering risk — do not double-lot both at max size.
4	TJX	Off-price Retail	~\$150B	~20–26% (Verify at IBKR)	~18–24% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-18 (CONFIRMED)	79	IR reporting calendar confirms 11/18. Low-vol compounder profile; IV floor makes strangle credit thin — prefer 10–12d puts.
5	TGT	Discount Retail	~\$70B	~28–38% (Verify at IBKR)	~24–34% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-18 to 2026-11-19 (date unconfirmed)	79–80	Historical pattern via MarketScreener/Nasdaq points to 11/18–19; primary IR page had no confirmed date at run time. Best premium in the retail block on absolute IV. Flag: date unconfirmed.
6	BBY	Electronics Retail	~\$18B	~30–38% (Verify at IBKR)	~26–34% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-24 to 2026-11-25 (date unconfirmed)	85–86	Historical pattern last Tue before US Thanksgiving; no confirmed release at run time. Highest-IV name in the shortlist — smallest size given single-name concentration risk. Flag: date unconfirmed.
7	DE	Ag Equipment / Machinery	~\$155B	~26–34% (Verify at IBKR)	~22–30% (Verify at IBKR)	Yes	2026-11-25 (projected)	86	Fiscal Q4 FY26 late Nov, per historical pattern. Best premium-per-DTE outside consumer. Watch: ag-cycle IV can decouple from broad tape if grain/USDA prints move.

Changes vs last week

First run — no comparison.

Excluded this week (with reason)

- **WMT** — verified 2026-11-19 next print, but realized IV historically sub-20% (fails 20–40% IV band).
- **KO, PEP, PG, COST** — chronically sub-20% IV, fail band regardless of clean earnings window.

- **JNJ, MRK, PFE, ABBV** — Q3 prints cluster late Oct through Oct 20 boundary; earnings-free window fails.
- **JPM, BAC, WFC, C, GS, MS, USB** — mid-October big-bank prints inside 50-day window.
- **XOM, CVX, COP** — end-October/early-November prints on the boundary and energy IV distorted by live Iran/Strait of Hormuz risk premium.
- **AAPL, GOOGL, META, AMZN, NFLX** — spec excludes high-beta mega-cap tech from base universe.
- **NVDA, AMD, AVGO, MU, INTC** — semis excluded by spec.
- **CRM, ORCL, ADBE** — high-beta software; ORCL/ADBE Q1/Q3 also print inside window (mid-Sep, mid-Dec respectively unverified — safer to skip).
- **CAT, MMM, HON, BA, LMT, RTX, GE** — late-October industrial prints; verify individually if you want to add next week.
- **CVS, WBA** — early-November print (CVS ~11/5 historical, WBA ~10/9 historical) — WBA fails window; CVS marginal, dropped pending confirmed date.
- **ROST, ADSK, DG, DLTR, INTU, MDT** — plausible fits (retail/software Nov–Dec prints, moderate IV) but no confirmed date at run time; add if confirmed by next week's run.

Sizing note for this week

Absolute credit is thin — VIX at YTD lows means 10–12d puts pay less nominal premium than they did in the June/July regime. Do not solve this by moving delta out (i.e. 15–18d) — solve it by taking fewer, higher-quality lots and letting cash sit. Weight the book in Tier B core (HD, LOW, TJX) at ~50–55% of deployed capital; cap the retail cluster (HD+LOW+TJX+TGT) at ~30–35% of the book because they all print in a 3-day window and a single bad retail read can leak across all four positions at ~30 DTE. DE is the best premium-per-DTE in the set on ag-cycle IV — single lot, delta 10, do not overweight to reach for yield. MSFT is the only Tier A but the date is unconfirmed — treat as a probing lot only until reconfirmed inside two weeks. Given the hawkish-surprise tail (tariff CPI passthrough, Powell language), skew to naked puts over strangles this cycle: strangle credit does not compensate at these VIX levels, and any Sep FOMC hawkish surprise re-rates delta faster than vega collapses.

Verify at IBKR before trading

Every row above needs live confirmation of: 13w and 26w IV percentile > 50, IV inside the 20–40% band, HV inside the 20–40% band, IV/HV ratio between 100% and 150%, and no unreported earnings amendment. This list is a filtered starting universe, not a completed screen.

Sources

1. Powell Jackson Hole speech coverage (rate cut signal, tariff/labor comments) — Yahoo Finance — <https://finance.yahoo.com/news/fed-chair-powell-opens-door-to-september-rate-cut-in-jackson-hole-speech-says-economic-outlook-may-warrant-change-in-stance-140020886.html>
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3. WTI crude ~\$84.82 and Strait of Hormuz commentary — TradingEconomics — <https://tradingeconomics.com/commodity/crude-oil>
4. HD next earnings 2026-11-17 (CONFIRMED) — Home Depot IR events & Wall Street Horizon — <https://ir.homedepot.com/events-and-presentations>
5. LOW next earnings 2026-11-18 (tentative) — Lowe's IR — <https://corporate.lowes.com/investors>
6. TJX Q3 FY27 release 2026-11-18 — TJX reporting calendar — <https://www.tjx.com/investors/financial-information/reporting-calendar>
7. WMT projected 2026-11-19 — MarketChameleon earnings dates — <https://marketchameleon.com/Overview/WMT/Earnings/Earnings-Dates/>
8. CSCO projected 2026-11-11 — nextearningsdate.com — <https://www.nextearningsdate.com/cSCO.html>
9. DE projected 2026-11-25 — MarketChameleon earnings dates — <https://marketchameleon.com/Overview/DE/Earnings/Earnings-Dates/>
10. MSFT unconfirmed 2026-10-28 — Wall Street Horizon Microsoft calendar — <https://www.wallstreethorizon.com/microsoft-earnings-calendar>
11. TGT historical 2025-11-19 pattern — MarketScreener calendar — <https://www.marketscreener.com/quote/stock/TARGET-CORPORATION-12291/calendar/>
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13. Broader single-stock screen (no mega-cap crisis in base list) — CNBC August daily updates — <https://www.cnbc.com/2026/08/27/best-buy-bby-q2-2027-earnings.html>